

Q Is it still possible to have a baby in our forties, or have we waited too long?

Women are increasingly having babies in their forties, particularly if they have assisted conception. Statistically, the odds aren't in your favor, but it depends on your individual circumstances and health.

Talk to your doctor if you haven't conceived after having unprotected sex for six months. He or she will begin initial tests (see opposite) to check whether you have any problems that could be affecting your fertility.

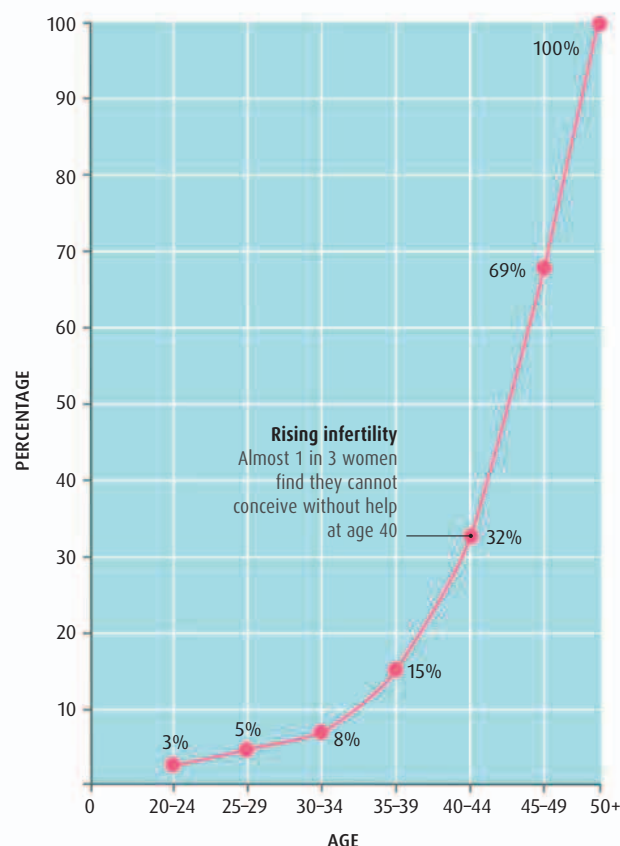
Do all that you can to maximize your fertility by making diet and lifestyle changes (see p.29). In addition to improving your chances of conceiving naturally, these changes will also ensure you are in the best possible health for pregnancy and parenthood.

You may be advised that your best option of conceiving is to have fertility treatment. Using donated eggs is often an effective treatment for women who are in their forties. This is combined with in vitro fertilization (IVF) to try to achieve a pregnancy. Be aware that IVF can cost thousands of dollars, and the procedure may not be covered by your health insurance. Even if it is covered, you may be limited on how many cycles of IVF you can try before you pay out of pocket, so keep your budget in mind.

The number of babies born to women who are 40 and over has **more than quadrupled** over the last three decades.

AVERAGE RATES OF INFERTILITY IN WOMEN

Women are most fertile in their 20s, with only a 3 percent likelihood of being infertile. By age 35 this has risen to 15 percent and by age 40, a woman has a 32 percent chance of infertility. Women in their late forties have a 69 percent likelihood of infertility.



Biological clock As this graph shows, a woman is nearly twice as likely to have fertility issues at age 35 as she did at age 30. That likelihood doubles again by 40.

KEY

● Likelihood of infertility

Q Is it true that it's more common to have twins when you are older?

Since women over the age of 35 are more likely to release more than one egg per cycle, yes, they do have a higher chance of conceiving a multiple pregnancy. Another reason is the number of older women who are taking advantage of assisted conception, which carries with it the possibility of a multiple pregnancy because the treatments sometimes use more than one embryo at a time. Multiple pregnancy is the biggest risk factor to an unborn baby, due to the high chance of premature birth.

Q My partner is a few years older than I am. Will this affect how long it takes us to conceive?

Male fertility begins to decline after the age of 40, when the quality of the sperm deteriorates. This can affect the health of the children born to the man as well as having an impact on his rate of fertility. Statistically, the average time for a man to conceive with his partner if he is under 25 is just four-and-a-half months; if the female partner is under 25 and the man is 40, it is likely to take nearly two years—five times as long—to conceive.

Q We've been trying to get pregnant for six months. Do we need to see a doctor?

If you are under 35, the recommended time to wait before consulting your doctor is one year. In the meantime, try not to worry, maintain a healthy lifestyle, and keep having sex regularly.

If you are over 35, or have a history of gynecological issues, you are more likely to have problems conceiving. See your doctor if you've been unsuccessful after six months of trying to get pregnant so that the necessary tests and investigations can be done.